

The National Games of India—which were last held in Kerala in 2015—are back after a gap of seven years. More than 7,500 athletes from 36 states/UTs are participating in the 36th National Games which will conclude on October 12, 2022. The prestigious multi-event sporting showcase will be held across six cities of Gujarat—Ahmedabad, Surat, Rajkot, Vadodara, Bhavnagar, and Gandhinagar. This is the first time Gujarat is hosting the National Games.

LEGACY OF THE NATIONAL GAMES

The National Games, initially called the Indian Olympic Games, were launched in 1924 to promote development of sports and create an Olympic movement in India. Over the years, participating in the National Games has become an aspiration for athletes from across the country. The Games are also a preparation for the athletes to compete in international competitions.

Despite having a short time to prepare for the Games—less than three months as against the usual period of two to four years for such mega events—Gujarat is pulling off the Games with aplomb, a record in itself. It is fair to claim that no other sporting event of this scale would have been organised in such a short duration of time anywhere in the world. Gujarat shows that anything is possible in New India under the statesmanship of the Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi.

OVERVIEW OF THE 36TH NATIONAL GAMES

As India celebrates Azadi ka Amrit Mahotsav, Gujarat is organising the 36th National Games from 29th September to 12th October, 2022 across six cities.

Conducting the Games across several cities will boost the local economy, one of the main reasons for bringing the Games to Gujarat. Moreover, this will bring together youth, students and aspiring sportspersons from across the state.

The 36th National Games are being held in 36 sports disciplines, the highest number in any edition of the National Games. These include both indigenous and modern sports like Yogasana, Mallakhamb, Kabaddi, Swimming, Badminton, Volleyball, Basketball, Hockey, Golf, Kayaking. Triathlon, Canoeing, etc. Gujarat, Haryana, Maharashtra, Karnataka and Punjab have the largest contingents with around 400 to 650 players in each team participating. More than 1,100 medals are on offer. Over 2,800 volunteers have come forward to make the Games a success.

MASCOT AND ANTHEM

The Mascot and Anthem for the National Games were launched on 4th September, 2022 at TransStadia, Ahmedabad. During the event, the website and mobile application of the Games were also launched. The Mascot, inspired by the Asiatic lion. is called 'Savaj' which means 'cub' in Gujarati. It symbolises strength, vigour, confidence and resilience. The anthem is titled "Judega India, Jeetega India" which suggests how sports is a critical unifying factor for the nation. The anthem's lyrics tell the tale of young Indians who find inspiration in sites like the Sabarmati Riverfront, Statue of Unity, Rann of Kutch, etc to win. The anthem also projects the emotion of a sportsperson fighting all odds to excel.

CREATING A BUZZ

To create awareness about the Games, a college/university and school activation campaign was organised from 12-17 September, 2022. Campaigns were held across all 2500+ colleges/universities and 33,000+ schools of Gujarat during which the students and teachers participated in sporting activities and also took the "Fit India" oath. This initiative was pivotal as it served as a medium to connect over 50 lakh students with the National Games. The mega campaign generated awareness for the Games in colleges and schools right from the village to city levels.

LOGO AND THEME

The logo of the 36th National Games, featuring the Asiatic Lion and symbolising the aspiration and fierceness of sportspersons, was launched by Gujarat's Hon'ble Chief Minister Shri Bhupendra Patel on 22nd July, 2022 at Mahatma Mandir, Gandhinagar. The theme of the Games—"Celebrating Unity through Sports"—was also unveiled the same day. Inspired by the Statue of Unity, the theme symbolises "Ek Bharat, Shrestha Bharat".